

THEGAPBRIEF · SIDE REPORT · OCTOBER 27, 2026

Should Rich Buy a Kenworth Truck and Trailer? Costs, Pay and King County Work in the Pipeline

What a Kenworth truck-and-trailer costs to buy and run in 2026, what it can earn in King County, and where the work is coming from. Written for Rich.

Assigned by Jacob Peterson for his dad, Rich · Research. Prices checked Oct 27, 2026. Every claim links to its source; numbers appear only where a cited source states them.

SUMMARY Bottom line for Rich

1 Recommendation: buy used, line up work first, start as a sub or through a broker

The upside is real. A truck-and-trailer driver on King County public works must be paid at least **$86.95 an hour** (L&I, effective Sept 2, 2026), and Seattle–Tacoma private hauling is quoted at **$130–$250 an hour** depending on truck size. Big public jobs keep coming: West Seattle Link, I-405, SR 520, I-5 paving and King County sewer projects.

The safest way in is a **good used Kenworth T880 (about $42,500–$115,000 in current WA listings) with a used pup trailer ($11,000–$16,000)**, not a new $318,500 truck. Before buying, get a written insurance quote (new ventures run $14,000–$20,000+ a year) and get on the call list of at least one broker or prime. Don't buy a new rig on hope; buy a used one once there's a phone number that will call you Monday morning.

L&I King County teamster rates (via PrevailingWageHub) · Dump Truck Academy Seattle–Tacoma rates · FreightWaves insurance ranges

BUYING What the truck and trailer cost right now

2.1 Truck: new Kenworth T880

Papé Kenworth in Federal Way lists a **new 2025 T880 Super Dump at $318,500** (MX-13, 510 hp, Allison automatic), and that price is *before* federal excise tax (FET) and local sales tax. FET on new heavy trucks adds a big chunk on top, so ask the dealer for an out-the-door number.

Papé Kenworth, 2025 T880

2.2 Truck: used Kenworth T880 / W900 in the region

- **2016 T880**, MX-13, 452,000 mi, wet kit: **$42,500** (Darling Sons, Snohomish). listing
- **2015 T880** 5-axle dump, MX-13 500 hp, 414,275 mi: **$115,000** (Papé, Federal Way). listing
- **2020 T880**, Cummins X15 565, 305,043 mi, truck only: **$110,000** (by owner, Sandpoint ID; posted March 2026). listing
- **2019 T880** 14x4 super dump, Chehalis: price not shown. listing

- **W900s** show up mostly at auction (e.g. a 2004 W900 tri-axle dump on a Ritchie Bros. sale in Chehalis, 343,619 mi, check-engine light). listing

Listings come and go; call before driving out. For any used truck, pay a Kenworth shop for a pre-purchase inspection and pull the emissions (DPF/DEF) history.

2.3 Trailer: pup or transfer

- **2000 Sturdy Weld 3-axle pup**, Eatonville: **$16,000**. listing
- **1998 Beall 12-yard pup**, Puyallup: **$15,000**. listing
- **Used truck-and-transfer set** (Peterbilt 579 with 2002 Reliance transfer): **$118,000** as one package, per a listing aggregator. Nationwide Haul
- **New transfer box:** we couldn't find a current published new price for a Western WA transfer box. Dealer data for new MAC transfer trailers runs about **$82,800–$86,400**. Nationwide Haul Get quotes from Western Trailer, Reliance or Beall.

A pup is cheaper and simpler. A transfer gets more legal payload on longer aggregate runs but costs more and takes more skill to run. Starting with a pup is the cheaper test.

FINANCING

Loans and down payments

3.1 What lenders are quoting in 2026

- Strong credit (650–720+ FICO) and 2+ years in business: about **7%–14% APR**, **0%–10% down**, 24–72 month terms.
- Fair credit: about **12%–18% APR**, **15%–20% down**. Subprime: 18%–28% APR, 20%–35% down.
- A brand-new business should plan on **10%–25% down**. Ask for a seasonal payment schedule (smaller winter payments).

Rich's own credit and history will set the real rate; a startup usually lands in the middle to upper part of these ranges.

BestTruckingLoans · Bay Street Lending · NerdWallet

RUNNING COSTS

Fuel, insurance, upkeep, permits, taxes

4.1 Fuel

The West Coast diesel average for October 2026 is about **$7.30 a gallon**; the Oct 26 weekly reading was **$7.329**. EIA doesn't publish a separate Washington diesel price. Fuel is the cost that moves the most, so ask whether a job pays a fuel surcharge.

EIA West Coast diesel prices

4.2 Insurance

- New dump truck business: **$14,000–$20,000+ a year** (FreightWaves). Local owner-operator with history: $8,000–$12,000.
- Dump truck pulling a trailer, per power unit: **$13,000–$20,000** (Garzor, clean records).
- Seattle–Tacoma single tandem: $7,000–$12,500 (Dump Truck Academy).

- Primes often require $1M+ auto liability and an umbrella ($2,500–$6,000/yr) to get on site.

FreightWaves · Garzor Insurance · LogRock

4.3 Maintenance and tires

We didn't find a reliable published Puget Sound figure for yearly dump truck maintenance or tire cost, so we don't give one. Ask the Kenworth dealer's service desk for a quote on a typical year for the exact truck, and ask a working local hauler. The illustration below uses a placeholder that is clearly marked as our assumption.

4.4 Licenses and permits (Washington)

- **CDL Class A** for the driver, since truck plus trailer is a combination vehicle. WA DOL CDL
- **WA business license / UBI number** through the Department of Revenue. WA DOR business license
- **USDOT number** from FMCSA (Washington requires one for intrastate commercial vehicles too). MC authority only if hauling for hire across state lines. FMCSA registration
- **IRP plates and IFTA** are only needed if the truck crosses state lines. For a 105,500 lb dump truck on Washington's IRP chart, the full-year WA license fee is **$3,376.20** plus a 15% freight fee (**$506.43**) and small filing fees. A King County-only truck registers in-state by gross weight instead. WA IRP Manual · 2026 WA IRP fee chart
- **Public works:** anyone working on public jobs files L&I intents and affidavits and follows the trucking rule (WAC 296-127-018). WAC 296-127-018

4.5 Taxes

A new truck pays federal excise tax on top of the sticker price (Papé's price excludes it), plus Washington sales or use tax at the local rate. Hauling for hire in Washington is generally taxed under the public utility tax rather than regular B&O. Ask a WA tax pro to confirm the rate for Rich's setup. There's also federal Heavy Vehicle Use Tax (Form 2290) for trucks 55,000 lb and up.

WA DOR public utility tax · IRS Form 2290 · WA sales/use tax rate lookup

EARNINGS What the truck can earn

5.1 Public works floor: $86.95/hr

L&I's King/Pierce/Snohomish rate for **Truck Driver, Dump Truck & Trailer** is **$58.43 base + $28.52 fringe = $86.95/hr**, effective Sept 2, 2026. That is the *driver's* minimum wage on public jobs, not what the truck rents for. Equipment is paid on top in the hourly rate a prime pays a hauler. Rates lock at the bid date, and L&I's next update is due Feb 1, 2027.

PrevailingWageHub (L&I data) · L&I prevailing wage lookup

5.2 Private market hourly rates

Seattle–Tacoma planning ranges for 2026: tandem **$130–$180/hr**, tri-axle **$160–$220/hr**, quad/super dump **$180–$250/hr**, usually with a two-hour minimum. Night export-soil work downtown reportedly pays 10–15% more. We found no published Seattle rate specifically for truck-and-pup or truck-and-transfer, so get a quote sheet from a local broker.

Dump Truck Academy, Seattle–Tacoma · Washington rates

5.3 Own authority vs. working through a broker

- **Own authority:** keeps the full rate but pays top-tier insurance and has to find work and collect payment.
- **Broker or hauling company:** companies like Stone Resources dispatch dump trucks for import/export across King, Pierce and Snohomish. Dispatch services in the area advertise **5–8% of gross** on your own authority, or **8–12%** leased under theirs (Cargo Voyager). Leased-on operators typically pay much less insurance: $2,000–$5,000/yr (BulkLoads).
- Also call the aggregate yards (Miles Sand & Gravel, Cadman) to get on their hauler lists.

5.4 Break-even example (illustration only)

This is our illustration, not a quote. Sourced inputs are marked [S]. Inputs marked [A] are our assumptions, so swap in real numbers.

- Rig: 2015 T880 $115,000 [S] + used pup $16,000 [S] = $131,000. 15% down ≈ $19,650 [A within sourced 15–20% range]; $111,350 financed at 12% [S range] for 60 months ≈ **$2,477/mo, $29,724/yr**.
- Insurance: **$14,000/yr** [S, low end for a new venture].
- Registration/IRP: about **$3,900/yr** [S, WA IRP fee + freight fee].
- Maintenance and tires: **$20,000/yr** [A, placeholder].
- Fuel: 5 gallons per working hour [A] × $7.33 [S] ≈ **$36.65 per hour**.
- Rate: **$150/hr** [S, inside Seattle–Tacoma ranges]. Billed hours: **1,500/yr** [A, about 30 hrs/week × 50 weeks allowing for rain days].

Result: yearly fixed costs ≈ $67,600. Each billed hour leaves ≈ $113 after fuel, so break-even is about **600 billed hours a year** (about 12 hours a week). At 1,500 hours the truck would gross $225,000 and clear roughly **$102,000 before Rich's own pay, income taxes and any broker cut**. At $130/hr, break-even rises to about 725 hours. If he hires a driver instead of driving himself, public-works pay of $86.95/hr would eat most of the margin on those jobs.

PIPELINE Work coming up in King County and nearby

6.1 Sound Transit

- **West Seattle Link Extension:** construction management expected winter 2026; major bridge, tunnel, guideway and station contracts planned for 2027. That means a lot of excavation and export haul. Sound Transit update
- **Tacoma Dome and Everett Link:** still in environmental review, with construction procurement later (2027–2028). Everett Link
- Watch the Procurement Lookahead and the Regional Contracting Forum deck to see who wins, then call those primes.

6.2 WSDOT

- **I-405 Renton to Bellevue widening and express toll lanes:** delayed, opening now expected 2027. WSDOT · KING 5
- **SR 520 Portage Bay Bridge and Roanoke Lid:** under construction by Skanska. SR 520 Construction Corner

- **I-5 and I-90 concrete panel preservation (Federal Way to Shoreline):** planned for spring 2027 with night and full closures. That means haul-off of old concrete. WSDOT

6.3 King County and City of Seattle

- **King County Wastewater** lists upcoming jobs: South Plant treatment and electrical improvements (about $172M), Brightwater roof/HVAC/solar (about $40M), and the Lake Hills/NW Lake Sammamish interceptor (about $165M, advertising July 2027). Q3 2026 list · Opportunities page
- **Ship Canal Water Quality Project** (Seattle Public Utilities and King County): final conveyance work through late 2026, full operation targeted 2027. SPU
- Private work: tech campuses, transit-area housing and Port of Tacoma jobs drive much of the regional demand. Dump Truck Academy

6.4 How a one-truck hauler gets on these jobs

- **Sub to the primes:** haulers work for the excavation and paving primes, not the agency directly. Find winning primes on bid tabs, then drop off a COI, W-9 and rate sheet at their job trailers.
- **Get certified:** Washington OMWBE certifies DBE/MBE/WBE firms (DBE requires 51% ownership by a socially and economically disadvantaged owner). King County's Small Contractors & Suppliers (SCS) program is size-based, and OMWBE-certified firms get it through Fast Track. Primes need certified subs to meet project goals, so this is a real door-opener.
- **Brokers and yards:** Stone Resources, area dispatch services, and gravel and asphalt suppliers keep hauler call lists.
- **Watch the portals:** Sound Transit, WSDOT contracting, King County, and the Regional Contracting Forum, where primes and small subs meet.

RISKS What can go wrong

7.1 The big risks

- **Rain and seasonality:** Western WA runs year-round but with rain delays, and earthwork slows in the wet months. Ask lenders for seasonal payments. source
- **Fuel swings:** diesel is already over $7 on the West Coast. Push for fuel surcharges or hourly rates.
- **Slow-paying primes:** subs often wait 30–60+ days or longer for payment. Keep 2–3 months of costs in cash, or use a broker that pays faster.
- **Project delays:** I-405 has already slipped to 2027, and transit starts depend on procurement schedules.
- **Insurance shock:** new ventures pay the most, and one claim can raise the renewal.
- **Used truck surprises:** high-mile emissions systems and the engine are where the big repair bills hide.

NEXT STEPS

Rich's checklist

8.1 In order

- Get a written insurance quote and a financing pre-approval first. They decide whether the numbers work.
- Call Stone Resources, two dispatch services and two gravel yards. Ask what they pay truck-and-pup per hour and how fast they pay.
- Shortlist two or three used T880s plus a pup, and get an inspection before paying.
- Set up the business license/UBI, USDOT number and CDL A. Consider SCS (and OMWBE if eligible).
- Go to the next Regional Contracting Forum and meet the West Seattle Link and WSDOT primes.

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